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Lizard Investors Embraces Niche Identity Within Int'l Equity Space

Jon Moog was in the right place at the right time nearly 20 years ago while seeking an opportunity to join an "entrepreneurial investment firm."

Moog's career consisted of working as an associate at Loomis, Sayles & Company and a senior analyst at H.I.G. Capital when a professor at his alma mater, The University of Chicago Booth School of Business, connected him with Leah Zell, an international small-cap equity investor looking to launch her own firm.

After serving as co-founding partner and portfolio manager at Wanger Asset Management, Zell founded Lizard Investors in 2008 and brought on Moog as a principal/senior analyst to build the firm's investment process.

"It was a great opportunity for me to help be part of the founding of a firm and a team," Moog said. "I was very excited to be operating in an area where I felt like active management is still very relevant, which was international small-cap."

Lizard, whose name pays homage to the mascot of Wanger's international team, prides itself on investing within a niche of equity markets, focusing on high-quality businesses through its international small-cap and emerging markets strategies, according to Moog.

"Our definition of quality is fairly simple, but what we ultimately are looking for is to invest in businesses that we can generate very high returns on invested capital over time," he said. "Oftentimes in small-caps, we're looking at monoline or simpler

business models that don't have multiple divisions and multiple products. So, what we really try to identify is what drives the business: 'What is better about the company's product or solution in the market? Why is this company going to be able to continue to gain market share or grow their market over a long period of time with high returns on capital? What do they do that is really special?' Understanding that engine of business is really the core of our investment process."

The Chicago-based firm then considers a company's balance sheet strength, management alignment and corporate governance as the remaining "building blocks that are really critical when we think about every investment we make, how we think about quality in a business and downside protection," he added.

"We are really trying to build a bottom-up portfolio with those quality attributes and then diversify across industry, sector, geography, and to some extent, currency to make sure that we're not taking too much thematic risk across any one vector," Moog said.

Lizard launched its inaugural strategy, the Lizard International Fund, in January 2009 utilizing a hedge fund structure to invest in the international small-cap space and expanded with the addition of two long-only strategies, Lizard ACWI ex Small Cap and Lizard EAFE Small Cap, in 2020.

"While the hedge fund, the LP structure, owns about 20 names in a very concentrated small-cap strategy that is quite capacity



Jon Moog

constrained, the ACWI ex-U.S. and EAFE strategies hold about 40 names and are a little more scalable from a liquidity perspective in the markets and are more institutionally geared," Moog said. "From our perspective, what we have is one investment process that can generate ideas around the world outside of the U.S and format is really driven by client demand. Some of our clients want ACWI ex-U.S., some want EAFE and then we have a lot of family offices in the more concentrated vehicle that's a little more capacity constrained."

"For our firm, we put a lot of investing into technology to allow us to offer SMAs and offer variations of our solution that we think are important for clients rather than just trying to channel everyone into one commingled vehicle," he continued.

Lizard has grown to approximately \$260 million in assets with "a significant majority of that being in the international

LIZARD: Firm Sees "Massive" Valuation Discrepancy In Non-U.S. Stocks

Continued From Previous Page

small-cap space, the SMA strategies and the LP structure," according to Moog.

The firm also manages a \$54.7 million global small-cap core mandate for the \$77.3 billion Maryland State Retirement & Pension System through emerging manager-of-managers Xponance as of June 30, according to data compiled by EMM.

Moog noted that Lizard has undergone several staff changes in the past decade, including his appointment as head of research and deputy portfolio manager in 2014 and cio and portfolio manager in 2017.

Further, the firm was bought by Australian asset manager Pengana Capital Group following Zell's retirement in January 2020, he said.

"The concept was that we were going to be a core investment team for Pengana and they were going to put other investment teams around us, build out marketing, back office and kind of grow as a sort of hub-and-spoke boutique," Moog explained.

"COVID obviously hit soon thereafter and Pengana did not make any more investments in terms of investment teams, so we were sort of on our own from 2020 to 2023, and at that point it just made more sense to buy back the firm myself. The dominance of U.S.

returns from 2018 through 2024 made it challenging for a lot of international strategies and I think the timing, from my perspective of international looking very attractively valued, combined with sort of a shift in market momentum behind international was really part of the impetus to try to buy the firm back at that time."

Upon Lizard becoming employee-owned, Moog sought to "add to the investment process in a meaningful way" by hiring Emerging Markets Portfolio Manager Sudin Poddar, who brought on the Lizard Emerging Markets Strategy, in 2024.

Poddar has been running the strategy, "which is based on a life cycle framework," for 12 years and most recently worked at Glovista Investments, according to Moog.

He "brings a wealth of knowledge and some investment tools that he has developed that are really applicable for our space," Moog added.

Specifically, the duo has built a proprietary research platform that systematically covers more than 20,000 companies and helps screen for and identify high-quality businesses, he said, noting that Lizard has also developed a "sort of shopping list of about 500 companies that we track closely."

"We're looking for fundamental inflections in businesses, and what

we've developed is a system that allows us to see when those inflections are happening on a fundamental basis, so that we make sure that we're spending time on the most appropriate ideas we can and that's really critical in terms of a universe as large as ours," Moog continued. "I think some of the tools and technology we have combined with our knowledge base in the niche that we operate in, allows for a unique ability for a small team to generate very timely ideas and cover a pretty wide swath of the universe while not wasting time on ideas that are not applicable to the quality strategy we run."

Moog hopes to expand Lizard's investment team in the "relatively near term" and gain momentum from the overall "resurgence in interest in the space we operate in."

"We've seen this massive valuation discrepancy between U.S. and non-U.S., and the valuations that quality non-U.S. small-cap companies are trading at are just set up for a very nice long-term return profile," he said. "My goal is to continue to educate people on the opportunity in the market, which we think is really substantial. We have a process that we think is really unique, specifically designed for our space and, as we add people, we want to continue to drive that process forward and allow it to kind of produce returns over time from both an idea generation standpoint and diligence standpoint."

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